

Old Nicks began sauntering in to the venue at Snyder Park on Sunday afternoon following on a very heavy rain squall. We joked about the fact and searched about for plastic bags, anoraks, or other waterproof items that might protect us during the game. The rain was accompanied by intermittent wind. But the team was in good spirits and were happy to have some subs. George Karambalas, who has played for years in the club showed up to celebrate turning 58. Greg Bost, another longtime club player stepped in to cover goal for us. We felt confident.

The 2pm start ticked over and no referee was in sight so your truly took the whistle and the sides agreed to play a friendly now that we were all present. Of course, three minutes after the start of the friendly, an official trotted over the hill and so we began again.

The rust from the break after summer showed on both sides—awkward passing and lack of focus—was on display. Nicks shrugged it off first and began to organize passes forward. After three or four runs that had been broken up by the Imperial defense, a ball through the line came to the feet of George K. He settled despite bounces and kept focus. The keeper, one Steve Graboyes came out fast in a crouch. George judged his touch well and put the ball past the keeper and into goal giving the Nicks a 1-0 start.

Imperials did not seem disheartened by the lapse—instead it made them focus and **Nicks** found themselves increasingly under pressure. Runs and shots at our goal were ably picked off or deflected by Greg and the ball headed back toward the Imperial goal. However, the increased pressure led to lapses in our own end—and for much of the rest of the half, Nicks found it difficult to play out in any numbers. Eventually, Chris Borne got loose with the ball and equalled the score. Not much later, a cross from the corner caught him free and running across the face of goal with a ball perfectly set for his head, but he didn't get purchase on it. Nicks breathed a sigh of relief. However, it was Borne again (no it's not a pun) who was loose and slotted in the second Imperial goal. The second half saw a resolute series of attacks by Nicks. Through valiant effort by the midfield, we earned a PK. Kim took the cross and sent it from the far post into the scrum about seven feet in the air. purposefully, Bruce Soderberg hit it with deliberation and the game was again tied. At that point, there was the usual back and forth down the field. And there were no Nicks who weren't part of the effort—it was heroic. Oh....and the rain had come down off and on so it was sodden...

The telling moment of the match came late in the game on a fluke. The ball was played from the left attacking side almost at the goal line. Greg Bost scampered forward to take it. Anatole was there too. But somehow confusion blinded them momentarily and the ball passed to the center of the goal where Steve Graboyes tapped it in for the win. **2-3 was the final**, though it was a hard-fought battle.

This match was marked by heroic moments from a range of players. Greg Bost in goal kept us in the game several times and was always calm. John Mayfield and Anatole on the back line were great at picking up Imperials attacks and disrupting them. Al and Jack Hevel and Roy Thompson showed their grit on the wings in not giving away much even though Imperials had several swift attackers. Mark Vogel and Bruce Soderberg did their best to connect the back to the attack—Bruce dancing through defenders several times while Mark used his best slalom technique to finesse the Imperials' defense. Late in the game, Bruce Barclay added his carefully chosen dribbles to give us another approach despite being seriously gimped. Robert Rivera played intensely trying to savage the opposing defense and win the ball until he had to leave the game with a foot injury. On the outside mid, Patrick Marcinko and Kim put their energy into creating space wide and overlapping when possible. Each of them had opportunities getting the ball into danger. Additionally, Kim provided the quality cross for our second goal. George Karambalas was a hard-working contributor and Russ gave 110% as an attacking threat and a disruptor of their counterattack.

We repaired after to Ancestry Brewing. Happily we don't play again out in Sherwood. I think the consensus was that Ancestry is not the place we want to go—too particular about who sits where instead of whether we can buy a beer.

Y'r Humble Manager...

David

Sept. 10, 2019